

shrinking away from it can loosen its hold on us and diminish its influence on our mindset and behaviour.

People-pleasing is a financial burden

When I started to discover where I'd gone wrong in my relationship with money, it didn't take long for one factor to come to the fore – something that had influenced my decisions again and again, from the kitchen of my hostel house-share in Australia to the newsfeed of my personal Instagram account. Other people. The weight of their opinions, the desire to impress them, the desperation not to disappoint them. My own sense of self was always in second place, and not even a close second, to the perception of me that other people had. I had a very clear idea of how I wanted to be seen, the impression that I wanted other people to have of me, and the financial cost of achieving that was not something I ever really considered.

For a very long time, praise from others was my nectar, the only thing sustaining me, keeping me from spinning off into an in-depth study of all of the things that were wrong with me. I came alive when I was making other people happy, but on my own I felt insufficient and unappealing. I let the lines blur between myself and those whose approval I sought, and I lived that way from my early teens until my late twenties. I had no idea how to have a relationship that didn't rely on transactions where I always had to be the one to give more. As I started to